

1. *The Conscious Mind* by Chalmers (1996)

1.1. Introduction

1.1.1. Taking Consciousness Seriously

About consciousness as an “illusion”:

Page xii

I have little idea what this could even mean. It seems to me that we are surer of the existence of conscious experience than we are of anything else in the world.

Doesn't an illusion require that there are things that are real, and things that just appear to be real, i.e., those illusions.

Chalmers starts with three constraints

- a. Take consciousness seriously
- b. Take science seriously
- c. Accept consciousness as natural phenomenon

Chalmers considers two problems or perhaps kinds of problems: The easy problems of consciousness that build upon the assumption that it can be understood by analysing cognition and behaviours. The hard problem is that those problems are insufficient for understanding the consciousness. These two sets of problems are on the opposite ends of a “Great Divide”. If you hold that the answer to an easy problem explains it all, you will get one theory. If you base your theory on the existence of hard problems it will be very different.

I argue that reductive explanations of consciousness impossible and I even argue for a form of dualism. But this is just a part of the scientific process. Certain sorts of explanation turn out to not work, so we need to embrace other sorts of explanation instead. Everything I say here is compatible with the results of contemporary science; our picture of the natural world is broadened, not overturned.

Page xiv

1.2. Foundations

1.2.1. Two Concepts of Mind

What is consciousness?

Chalmers doesn't use any definition of his own. His definition is formulated through Nagel (1974)

Page 4

We can say that a being is conscious if there is *something it is like* to be that being.

1.2.2. Phenomenal and Psychological

On the phenomenal concept, mind is characterised by the way it feels; on the psychological by what it does.

Page 11

Functionalism includes groups of positions sharing the idea that there exist mental states that cause behaviours.

Page 14–15

At a first approximation, phenomenal concepts deal with the first-person aspects of mind, and psychological concepts deal with the third person aspects.

Page 16

1.2.3. The double life of mental terms

A good test for whether a mental notion *M* is primarily psychological is to ask oneself: Could something be an instance of *M* without any particular associated phenomenal quality?

Page 18

1.2.4. The two mind-body problems

The fact that we have two kinds of mental properties has consequences.

Page 24

[...] effect of dividing the mind-body problem into two: an easy part and a hard part. The psychological aspects of mind pose many problems for cognitive science [...] but they pose no deep metaphysical enigmas.

Learning and memory are functions that belong to the easy ones. They might be connected with enormous technical problems, but hardly any metaphysical ones. They are 'puzzles' not 'mysteries'.

The phenomenal aspects of mind are a different matter. Here, the mind-body problem is as baffling as it ever was. The impressive progress of the physical and cognitive sciences has not shed significant light on the question of how and why cognitive functioning is accompanied by conscious experience. The progress in the understanding of the mind has almost entirely centered on the explanation of behaviour. This progress leaves the question of conscious experience untouched.

Page 25

Chalmers refers to this problem as the mind-mind problem.

References

Chalmers, David J., *The Conscious Mind: In Search of a Fundamental Theory*, Oxford University Press, New York (1996).

Nagel, Thomas, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" *The Philosophical Review* **83**, pp. 435-450 (1974). <https://doi.org/10.2307/2183914>.